

some wisdom that could turn the ornery into the next big thing from Ranchi.

The first is Mahendra Singh Dhoni, wicketkeeper-batsman, captain of India at the World Twenty20 and foremost candidate for GenNext leader. "It is like a door opened," says Munda, a Jharkhand under-15 and under-17 player. Ghosh's camp began in 1988-89 and he remembers pitching up to wait for two hours in the hope that someone would turn up. Now he can't stop them. Ranchi's club league now features 85 teams (from less than half the number even five years ago) and state selection trials pull in 600 aspirants. They all may want to be like Dhoni but not, they say, to bat like him because his success lies in his mind and his will and everyone's got that. Dilip Singh, 20, says, "*Koi extraordinary nahin hota* (no one is extraordinary)." So they train and do fitness, yoga and meditation and concentration drills that involve looking at a candle flame burning itself out. Suraj

Bhan Singh, a Jharkhand under-19 player, borrowed equipment before his family could afford a new kit and went to a cricket camp under Yograj Singh where he worked out so hard that he threw up. Ark Raj stood shaking on the pitch on his state debut till he hit the first two balls. Mohit Kumar, left arm spinner, is the son of a clerk in the Ranchi civil court and wants to bowl to Sachin Tendulkar. So what if he's 14. "You bowl with your brain," says the sharp boy.

These boys speak in the engaging dialect of self-effacement and regard: Dhoni is "Mahi bhaiyya" or "Dhoni bhai". But underneath, they wear confidence like it were a piece of branded gear. Not so long ago, they would be called *janglis* and told to go till fields. Now the Jharkhandis have a practised riposte for the big city boys. What are such softies doing in cricket, these guys with ketchup for blood? Jalan laughs, "We tell them to go home and sleep in the AC. We don't feel inferior, we feel we're better than them."



85

THE NUMBER OF TEAMS IN RANCHI'S LOCAL CLUB CRICKET LEAGUE

183

RUNS WAS MAHENDRA SINGH DHONI'S HIGHEST SCORE AGAINST SRI LANKA IN 2005